

DISLOCATION: VR experience

Veljko Popovic
veljko@primerst.com
Art Academy in Split
Croatia

Milivoj Popovic
milivoj@primerst.com
Prime Render Studio
Croatia



ABSTRACT

This work represents a non-narrative VR experience with elements of interaction. It consists of two parts. The art installation and the VR work itself. The VR work talks about dislocation- the enforced departure of people from their homes, typically because of war, persecution, or natural disaster. This film takes a look at an absurd moment of disbelief and fear. It examines the internal processes that develop and offers a visual depiction of a moment in time of a person forced to fight for his life in a strange land. A moment of dislocation. The VR installation is a tent that can be typically found in refugee camps (Figure 1). It takes approximately 12m square of space. VR headset is situated in the middle of the tent. On the right side of the entrance of the tent, there is a TV mounted that is showing an animated loop that gives context to the visual treatment of the main character. Inside the tent, there is a cardboard piece with the words “where is justice, where is humanity” written.

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1 INTRODUCTION

VR has been adopted as a medium for filmmaking in the past few years. It is still widely unexplored and there are no set canons or standards for filmmaking inside the VR environment.

This project explores the tools and techniques that allow for non-narrative and narrative filmmaking inside VR. The project regards interaction within the confines of filmmaking and as a tool that enhances the viewing experience rather than a tool for game-like engagement of the audience. Following the same idea, the project

examines the space outside the VR headset as a stage to enhance, support and expand the narrative or non-narrative structure of the experience.

2 DESIGN AND IMPLEMENTATION

Virtual reality allows for a more direct and engaging experience of a subject matter than standard film. For a subject such as this one, it is perfect as it places us in direct contact with the human tragedy of a refugee crisis. But the aim of the experience is not to document human suffering or to inform the viewer of a historical moment. We are taking a subject that has deeply affected us emotionally and are creating a fictional theatrical setting, almost performance like, to deal with our emotions regarding this matter in an effort to try and understand more deeply what happens in such a terrifying moment of being a refugee in a strange land, fighting for your life in face of complete uncertainty.

This pivotal moment in which a force outside our control completely changes a person's life is a matter that we have explored in our previous films, such as “Planemo” (<https://vimeo.com/291661331>) and “Dove sei, amor mio” (<https://vimeo.com/28194902>) and continue to explore in this work. We take a moment of uncertainty and fear and try to connect it with the same dormant fear that we all live with and have faced at some point in our life.

The VR experience “Dislocation” (Figure 2) is set in three locations - A beach (such you might find on the coast of Greece), the desert (such as the deserts around Mexico and the USA) and a forest somewhere in the Balkan region. We follow an unnamed protagonist in each of these spots, coping with the reality of his situation. He turns, looks, hides. He searches or tries not to be found. He is hunted by an unseen force, an unnamed enemy. The viewer moves from one scenery to the other by looking inside the protagonist, moving the headset inside the head of the character that stands there, in front of him. This transports the viewer first inside the mind of the protagonist (Figure 1), and then to the next location. This happens until the last location where the protagonist faces the force that now shapes his reality. In despair he screams, leaving us in darkness from which a set of documentary images

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of immigrants appear, showing us the final stop in this arduous, inhumane journey.

The VR installation is a tent that can be typically found in refugee camps. It takes approximately 11m square of space. VR headset is situated in the middle of the tent. Inside the tent, there is a cardboard piece with the words “where is justice, where is humanity” written (Figure 1). On the right-hand side of the tent, there is a looping animation showing the concept behind the visual of the main character. The character is constructed out of white lines which represent the routes and paths taken by the refugees on their journeys. This visual also negates any identity of the refugee, much as in real life the refugee loses all identity except that one of a “refugee.” (Figure 2)

3 FILM MAKING TOOLS INSIDE VR

In the absence of traditional filmmaking tools such as the frame, scene editing and camera movement we were forced to explore and identify other filmmaking tools available that can substitute the traditional tools available. The environment inside VR becomes a vital filmmaking tool. The structure of the scenery, lighting and sounds are used to create points of interest and guide the viewer. Aside from this, we use the movements of the main protagonist to

guide the viewer to certain places in the scenery, but without the viewer even noticing he is being guided.

This is vital as the viewer is in effect the camera inside VR. Using all these in perfect sync we are able to guide the viewer not only inside the VR experience but also to control his movement in the real world and confine it within the 3x3m space dedicated for the VR experience. Scene transitions are created again using the viewer as the “camera” where his movement triggers the next scene and progresses the film forward. This means the interaction is present but without the usage of controllers that distract from the experience. In the end, the viewer is guided so that his last position is in front of a cardboard piece with the words “where is justice, where is humanity?” written on it. The exact same sign can be seen in the last shot inside the VR experience. This bridges the gap between virtual reality.

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 Technical director: Dalibor Aljinovic Assistant to the TD: Darko Kokic
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